

29 September 2026

Dear Editor,

Please consider our manuscript, “Stress-Testing Citation Faithfulness in Open-Weight Retrieval-Augmented Generation,” for publication in your journal.

The manuscript examines how citation assignment changes when an answer phrase is inserted into retrieved documents. Extending prior citation-intervention work, we compare random, relevant-uncited, and cited-other document conditions across three open-weight instruction-tuned models on Natural Questions with KILT Wikipedia retrieval. We report both intervention availability and statement recovery, so the conditional rates can be assessed directly.

The main result is an observable citation shift toward some altered answer-bearing documents. We describe it as a stress-test outcome, since document position and retention of the original source differ across conditions; it cannot establish which source caused an answer. Auxiliary ConflictBank, activation-patching, and probe analyses clarify these limits. In particular, selected component scaling corrected no generation-level citation errors, and corrected hidden-state probes did not outperform simple baselines. The paper thus offers a transparent behavioral evaluation with explicit limits on causal and deployment claims.

This work is original, has not been published previously, and is not under consideration elsewhere. All authors have reviewed and approved the manuscript and agree with its submission. The authors declare no competing interests.

Thank you for your consideration.

Sincerely,

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